The Sorrows of Young Werther

Goethe's novel *The Sorrows of Young Werther* is one of the greatest achievements in the history of Western literature. Remarkably, it is in some respects the total inverse of Goethe's *Faust*, another of the great achievements of Western literature. Instead of the immense complexity of *Faust*, we find immense simplicity: the most basic and pedestrian human experience transformed into a description of internal emotional life that is, I think, unsurpassed in literature.

Goethe wrote *The Sorrows of Young Werther* in 1774, when he was twenty-four, and completed it in four weeks. That is the kind of achievement that makes one shrug and acknowledge that some people are naturally more gifted. We have to live with that unless we can produce something on the same level. Such an achievement can also spur us toward greater achievement ourselves. Werther is, in some respects, a paradigm of the passionate, almost crazily emotional young man.

I did not read the novel until I was twenty-five, and it moved me tremendously. It is an exceptionally powerful short read, roughly eighty or a hundred pages in some editions. I particularly like Victor Lange's translation, but anyone who reads German should read it in German. Few novels are more luminous and beautiful. It is accessible, unlike the effort of hacking one's way through the forest of *Faust*. It begs to be read because it is so lovely and elegant.

After reading it, I gave it to my roommate, a friend who had known me in college. He read it quickly and said, "Mike, you used to say things like this all the time." I immediately identified with Werther. When I was twenty or twenty-one, I had thought that I had invented emotion, that I had discovered it for the first time.

Part of the novel's point is that everyone, every generation, must invent love uniquely and as if for the first time. This is one of the perennial tendencies of human nature. Taken to its logical extreme, it reveals the connection between sex and death that occupies so much of Freud's writing. Ultimately, Goethe explores the limitations of the human mind and of living entirely within one's own soul, denigrating the external world—a characteristic of romantic young men, both Werther and the twenty-four-year-old Goethe.

The novel was immediately a sensational success across Europe. On the strength of four weeks' work, the young Goethe became one of Europe's leading intellectual figures. Its emotional power also caused alarm. There were reports of unhappy lovers imitating Werther, dressing like him and taking their own lives, sometimes with a copy of the novel among their possessions. The book's influence was not merely a literary joke: it became the subject of prohibitions. The concern was that its power over unhappy readers could have fatal consequences. At twenty-four, an author might scarcely know his own strength.

There is not much plot, and the characters are in some respects the most interesting part. Werther is one of the archetypal figures of Western literature: a naïve, self-absorbed egoist. He spends most of his life talking to himself and is largely oblivious

to the external world. To the extent that it interests him, it does so as something to strive for, an object of his own desires.

He is a romantic genius: a talented, clever young man with great potential, but with a little too much of everything. One might define Romanticism artistically as the loss of a sense of proportion. Romantic writers and musicians have too much of everything; Werther has far too much. He is too self-absorbed and egotistical, and he does not know himself.

He has the characteristic defects of superior young men, taken so far that their superiority becomes self-destructive and nihilistic. He lives through his emotions and for his emotions. The rest of the world is simply a vehicle for obtaining an emotional response.

Like other romantics, Werther cannot find a niche in society. He hates bourgeois society, with its prudent calculations and its pursuit of wealth, status, and power. He has no interest in accommodating himself to the necessities of practical economic life. Nor can he find a home in aristocratic society. Germany at this time is highly stratified, and Werther is not an aristocrat.

One important passage in the second part describes an aristocratic gathering from which he is required to leave because the aristocrats will not mingle with him. He fumes and rails against convention. All romantics do this, but Werther does it more than most. He decides that these supposed aristocrats are unworthy of him because most are insipid and useless. They have aristocratic status, but do not measure up to him person for person. That may be true, but it does him no good.

Corrupt society thwarts the talented, natural man. Werther is fond of nature, children, naïve people untouched by formal education, and the illiterate. These are qualities associated with the Romantic movement. The novel is one of the great achievements of *Sturm und Drang*. To see the essence of Romanticism, one can look at German culture in the early nineteenth century, not only at Goethe but also at Beethoven.

Almost the entire novel is in Werther's voice, expressed through letters. He does nearly all the talking, which tells us something about him: he does not listen to other people. He is almost impossible to talk to. He lives through himself and for himself, entirely selfish and egotistical. Although one admires him in a way, he is not very likable.

He is not self-sacrificing or devoted to a higher ideal. He is devoted to himself. Ultimately, he becomes solipsistic: he is the only thing in the universe, and everything else exists for his pleasure and convenience.

Albert is Werther's opposite. He marries Charlotte and represents bourgeois prudence, practicality, and solidity. I hated Albert when I first read the novel. He was everything I despised and everything Werther despises. Untamable, irresponsible young men are likely to hate him, and that is part of the point. He represents the social forces trying to bring this furious young man into line: solidity, practicality, and a sense of proportion, all of which Werther disdains.

Wilhelm, Werther's correspondent, is not extensively drawn. For the most part, he serves as a sympathetic foil, someone to whom Werther can write and pour out his heart, although Werther usually makes it difficult for others to sympathize with him.

Toward the end, the narration is taken up by an anonymous editor rather than by Wilhelm.

Charlotte is, for Werther, the most beautiful woman in the world. She is “das Ewig-Weibliche,” the eternal feminine associated with the end of *Faust*: something to strive for, something he wants with his whole heart and soul. She is the most valuable thing in the universe, the centre of creation, around which all the planets revolve.

The difficulty is that Charlotte is unimaginably commonplace. In this reading, she has almost no personality and is one of literature’s most boring women: passive, timid, and insipid. It is difficult to feel much sympathy for her. Werther has mythically inflated her into something analogous to Helen of Troy, the universally desirable object.

She is not exactly universally desirable, however, because Werther does not care what the universe thinks. He desires her, and his universe extends only to the limits of his skull. It exists within his mind; everything else is superfluous, an epiphenomenon of his experience. He has found something he likes and latched onto it. It becomes the centre of the universe, the zero-zero point on a Cartesian graph by which all other events in life are mapped.

Strictly speaking, he is crazy, but in a unique and wonderful way that recurs whenever someone discovers love for the first time. Most people eventually accommodate themselves to reality. For Werther, if reality will not accommodate itself to him, there is no deal. He represents the solitary, solipsistic romantic ego, the lone wolf unable to bend to social conventions, who moulds reality to suit himself.

In another historical circumstance, he might have been a hero, a Napoleon or a Goethe. Instead, through the simple facts of fate, he must confront the consequences of his untamed emotion. Sex, lust, and desire ultimately lead to death, to a negation of this life.

Most of the minor characters are women and children. One might describe a characteristic of the romantic novel as “women and children first.” The Enlightenment novel *Robinson Crusoe* has essentially no family life, scarcely any women or children, and little emotional life. People grew tired of this, and Romanticism followed the cultural tendencies of the Enlightenment.

Romanticism rebels against the cold, artificial, scientific formality of the Enlightenment. This is particularly evident in music, but also in literary art. It is difficult to imagine what romantic science would look like, but not what romantic novels or poems would look like. *Werther* is perhaps the greatest epitome of the romantic novel and the romantic hero or antihero.

Werther likes peasants and natural people. Those he dislikes are associated with large social institutions. Clergymen are disgusting because they do not understand real value; businessmen are swine interested in accumulating money. They do not understand that a sensitive man of taste goes into the countryside with his Greek copy of Homer and absorbs beauty directly. Werther spends much of his time doing precisely that.

Why would he want to talk to anyone else? The world is a spectacle between his ears. The external world is essentially unreal to him. It may upset him occasionally, but he denies its reality and regards his own experience as the only reality. He is reality unto himself. Romantic heroes would like to be God; failing that, they would like to worship

themselves. There is a connection between the religious impulse and Werther's solipsistic nihilism, which grows increasingly extreme.

The novel's form is wonderful and inspired. It is an epistolary novel, a novel composed of letters, and this serves many important functions. First, it allows Werther to do all the talking, his preferred mode of existence. His idea of conversation is talking to someone or something without receiving a reply. If someone does reply, he may read it to obtain more grist for his own mill, so that he can continue talking.

Mostly, Werther talks to himself. He does not want to listen to the external world, which is neither real nor important unless it gives him something to be excited about. He will tolerate it in that case, but its only value is that it excites him and gets him going.

Shakespearean soliloquies involve a certain loss of realism: a character comes forward and talks to himself. Prolong this sufficiently and the speaker may appear to belong in a psychiatric hospital. Consider Edmund in *King Lear*: "Thou, Nature, art my goddess; to thy law / My services are bound." He goes on to question legitimacy. A few more paragraphs and we might feel that he should be locked up.

There is a loss of realism when a character talks to himself about important philosophical issues in order to reveal his character. One cannot sustain this for a hundred pages. A vehicle is needed, and letters provide it.

We receive Werther's letters to his friend, not the friend's replies. Werther apparently receives those replies and may even read them, but what other people say makes little difference to him. Anyone who has tried talking to a nineteen-year-old in love recognizes the situation. Such people know that others may be more prudent and wiser, but those others are not real to them. Their feelings are the only reality. Each generation rediscovers this, and it will persist as long as people do.

Goethe achieved this portrayal at twenty-four, in four weeks. The form makes it possible for no one to reach Werther. He is solipsistic. Taken to its logical extreme, this attitude toward the world becomes nihilistic and self-destructive. He cannot deal with the consequences of rejecting society and embracing nature.

Aristotle called human beings social animals, but Werther is a natural man who withdraws from society because it is corrupt. Bourgeois society disgusts him, while aristocratic society refuses him and, in his view, consists of fools. The natural man, the solitary ego, withdraws.

The plot is astonishingly simple and pedestrian. Great art emerges from something as common as household dust: young people falling in love for the first time, living in their own world, beyond the reach of conversation. Goethe universalizes this experience and gives us an enduring account of what it is like.

A young man meets a young woman, falls in love, and discovers that she is already engaged—to the disgusting, swinish, bourgeois Albert. Werther is generous and noble-hearted and does not wish to interfere with his beloved. They develop a chaste, Platonic love that becomes increasingly intense. Platonic love is highly sexual; to think of it as disembodied is misleading. It is simply highly spiritual as well.

In the first book, Werther's voice dominates through his letters to Wilhelm. He becomes increasingly absorbed in Charlotte. The difficulty is that, in this interpretation, she has nothing interesting about her: no personality, only timidity, passivity, and insipidity. Yet Werther sees Helen of Troy and would face any danger to be with her.

The children love Charlotte, the romantic heroine, and they love Werther. Werther loves them because they are innocent and uncorrupted. There are lovely idyllic scenes of him in nature and with children, peasants, and Charlotte. The idyll is disturbed by her attachment to level-headed, prudent Albert, whom Werther regards with disgust.

These scenes are narrated in Werther's letters. We do not have an objective narrator reporting conversations; we have Werther's account of what Albert said. Albert's attitude amounts to this: Werther ought to get a job and do something useful in the world. Werther's answer is that he is already doing something useful: living, experiencing, existing at the cutting edge of reality. The implication is that Albert has no idea what it means to be alive, and Werther does not want to hear more from him.

It is difficult to imagine greater opposites than Werther and Albert. Increasingly, Werther is under pressure to act. He feels an emotional attraction to Charlotte, but she is engaged and then married. He does not want to force her out of the marriage and ruin her reputation. The social conventions of eighteenth-century Germany make that impossible.

This is failed, impossible love, rather than simply unrequited love. To the extent that Charlotte has emotional and interesting qualities, she too loves Werther, but cannot decide what to do. She is not a romantic heroine driven by immense, uncontrollable passions. Only Werther is.

His letters express a pantheistic love of nature. Goethe was drawn to Spinoza's philosophy. Werther and Spinoza have little in common apart from remarkable intelligence; one can hardly imagine a philosopher more opposed to Werther's romantic tendencies. Yet Goethe was attracted to the idea of God immanent in nature, associated with Spinoza's philosophy and often described, rightly or wrongly, as pantheism. This attraction is reflected in *Werther*.

Werther constantly complains that people talk too much and should draw more. He is tired of hearing them, although he hardly listens. He wants people to stop jabbering at him and leave him alone. We recognize such people, or remember having been like that ourselves. I was like this at that age, although I did not reach Werther's extreme.

His love of nature merges with his passion for Charlotte in religious ecstasy. He constantly has mystical visions, but they are not ethereal apparitions generated by God. They arise from nature. Their object is not a substance-less form but a woman whom he has mythically inflated into something like the Statue of Liberty, beyond the human scale. She possesses all human virtue and is the best conceivable woman. The real Charlotte has little to do with this image.

Charlotte is also the subject of Thomas Mann's twentieth-century novel *Lotte in Weimar*, known in English as *The Beloved Returns*. There she finally acquires a personality. It is ironic and very funny, but also interesting and serious. Readers who enjoy *Werther* are likely to enjoy Mann's novel as well.

As the first book closes, Werther decides that he must leave because he is going crazy. His letters show a gradual erosion of his sanity. They become wilder, while he becomes less inclined to dialogue. He increasingly talks to himself, grows morbidly introspective and withdrawn, and rejects the world, society, and the expectations placed upon an ordinarily adjusted person.

In the second book, he leaves and continues writing to his friend. The letters become less connected to reality. Away from Charlotte, he works for an ambassador and engages in affairs of state. He encounters educated people with literary interests, but finds the ambassador himself pedantic and increasingly intolerable.

This political employment has a connection with Goethe's later career. Goethe was not only one of Western culture's greatest poets and dramatists but also a statesman involved in Weimar's government. He was a scientific investigator and made original contributions to botany and the theory of colour. He was a truly universal genius with an intellectual Midas touch: almost everything he touched turned to gold.

Werther has some of this potential, the germ of Goethe's ability to do almost anything and do it exceedingly well. The difficulty is that he cannot get Lotte out of his mind. Living entirely within his own experience, he fails to recognize the significance of the external world. He returns to her, fatally.

Albert objects. Werther's presence must eventually irritate this prudent bourgeois husband. Yet Albert, having little passion in this reading, cannot muster much jealousy. Mostly he worries about what people will think. Werther is in love with his wife, and Albert is concerned with public opinion. He scarcely seems to know what love is; Werther knows a little too well.

If half Werther's emotion could be given to Albert, and some of Albert's prudence to Werther, they might become well-balanced human beings. Albert has too much prudence. Their discussions repeatedly turn to when Werther will get a job, settle down, and take things seriously. Werther's answer is that he already takes things altogether too seriously, and Albert does not understand.

They argue about emotion. Albert regards it as good up to a point, suitable for children and old ladies, but not something in which one should indulge excessively. Werther looks at him with contempt, feeling that he cannot talk to him or even remain in the same room. They are oil and water, incapable of mixing, representing the emotional and rational sides of human life.

Werther visits increasingly often. Albert worries about appearances and asks Charlotte to give him less encouragement: he comes every day while Albert is at work, and something must be wrong. Yet although the love is intensely emotional and ultimately sexual, it remains chaste. Werther is not living in the world of flesh and physical reality. They do not have sex; he barely touches her.

He wants to contemplate her as an icon of desirability. She is the eternal feminine, the ultimately creative principle that justifies existence, the realization of value in this world. He thinks he has discovered it for the first time and that this is its only instance. Everyone who first discovers it tends to think they have found the only instance.

Eventually Charlotte asks him not to come every day and spend all his time looking at her and dreaming. Albert objects to his presence, and, much as she likes him, the situation cannot continue. Werther confesses his love, chaste but profound and desperately moving. He kisses her in their final encounter, and she withdraws.

She is virtuous but also a conventional German wife. In this interpretation, she loves Werther but cannot admit it to herself because she does not possess his driving passions. She thinks the best solution would be to marry him to one of her friends. There would be no sexual threat, Albert would not be upset, and she could see Werther all the time without difficulty.

She considers her friends one by one and finds none suitable. None really deserves Werther. She is deceiving herself: she really loves him. How could a young woman fail to enjoy this adulation and worship? Albert does not offer that. He provides food and practical security.

After the kiss and Lotte's rejection, Werther is desperately hurt, wounded to the soul. He does not want an adulterous relationship; he wants Lotte completely. He would like to remove Albert, whom he dislikes on principle, not merely because Albert is married to her. He would like to eliminate all the Alberts from the world.

Werther goes home profoundly upset, sends his servant to pay his debts, and decides that he must kill himself. His apparent calm is anything but lucidity. It resembles the eye of a hurricane. His study is quiet, and that external quiet is the inverse of the turmoil within him, now at its highest intensity.

His final writing becomes almost incoherent. He can worship nothing but Charlotte; nothing else matters, and he cannot stop his racing thoughts. A modern reader might think in terms of illness and medical treatment, whereas here the crisis is presented as a problem of the human condition. In another century, the language is different. He claims to have calmly decided to end his life.

Goethe has extraordinary touch. Some athletes are naturally powerful or fast, but others possess touch. All good basketball players approach the basket, but not all have that special delicacy of control. Goethe has it. The few pages in which Werther dies are among the most wrenching in literature.

Werther sends to Albert and Lotte's house. She feels guilty after being kissed by another man and does not know what to say to her prudent bourgeois husband. Albert asks whether she has spoken to Werther and discouraged him. She answers nervously. Their domestic conversation concerns ordinary, trivial matters, while Werther's request announces a journey and asks to borrow Albert's pistols.

Lotte has a premonition of his suicide. She knows how disturbed he is. The request for the pistols, ostensibly for protection on his journey, is devastating. For the first time, in this reading, she undergoes a genuine psychological crisis. She feels guilty and knows that Albert will not understand this chaste yet tremendously passionate relationship.

She wonders what sort of journey Werther means: leaving the locality, or leaving the world? Has he, in another sense, always been outside the world? Even a soap opera scarcely reaches this emotional intensity. She sees the man she loves, but has not married, borrowing pistols.

Lotte is the last person in her household to touch them before they are sent. When Werther receives them, he takes comfort in the fact that they have passed through her hands. In his final letter, he finds pleasure and reassurance in her touch. Romanticism takes emotion almost as far as it can go.

A servant brings the pistols, and Albert is glad Werther is leaving. He lends them and wishes him a good journey. He can return them whenever he likes. The ironies multiply and become increasingly painful. A reader's pulse races as the outcome becomes clear, as inevitable as the ending of a Greek tragedy, yet it is impossible to stop turning the pages.

Few books make one read faster. Breath and heartbeat quicken; one is drawn into the romantic current. It is difficult to imagine a better hundred-page novel. Anyone with an emotional life will be seized by it. Anyone who has been a passionate, romantic twenty-year-old will recognize the experience. Those who have not will understand what they missed. Either way, the novel takes its reader by the throat emotionally.

Werther settles his debts with great deliberation. Perhaps this is a final acknowledgment of Albert's prudence: he does not wish to leave owing anyone anything. He has no use for the money; his journey will not require it. He sits at his desk, writes, and leaves letters, including a farewell to Lotte. These final communications heighten the emotional effect.

He then eats bread and drinks wine. This is, in my reading, a parody of the Mass, a kind of black Mass that negates rather than affirms, directed toward despair rather than hope. It is nihilistic worship of himself rather than God, because he recognizes nothing outside himself.

After this parody of the Mass, at midnight, Werther shoots himself. The shot is heard, but is taken for an accidental discharge. The novel uses a set of coincidences, and one does not ask too much of those in this kind of narrative. He does not die immediately, but lives until noon the next day: from midnight to high noon.

The wound in the head can be read in connection with the mark of Cain. Cain killed his brother; Werther kills himself, and for him that is all there is to kill, because nothing else is real. This is an abolition of reality altogether, nihilistic ego-worship. It suggests that the romantic stance toward the world is ultimately self-destructive and nihilistic. The parody of the Mass makes explicit the self-worship that has always been present.

In the morning, the servant finds him. He is still alive, badly wounded, and is placed on a bed. His death is expected, but he lingers for hours. In the Christian framework invoked here, his suicide expresses despair and places him outside the religious and social order. He receives no absolution in the narrative.

Despair is opposed to hope, one of the great Christian virtues. By taking his life, Werther has given up on the world and on the hope it offers. He stands outside organized society and the Christian religious order because he cannot satisfy his solipsistic, nihilistic desires.

Goethe's final page is beautiful. Given the emotional intensity of the novel's beginning and middle, one expects a long, terribly moving scene when Lotte and Albert learn what

has happened. Instead of pages of shrieking and lamentation, there is one sentence: “I shall say nothing of Albert’s distress, or of Charlotte’s grief.”

The understatement makes this extraordinarily powerful. Its restraint contrasts so sharply with everything around it that the line alone is overwhelming. It is worth the price of admission by itself. Werther finally dies and is buried without a clergyman. The final words are: “No priest attended.”

That absence is a pregnant idea. First, Werther has acted as his own clergyman. His act is a ceremony that negates rather than affirms life. Second, he does not worship God; he worships himself. Naïve sentimental egoists worship themselves. The solipsistic insistence that only one’s own feelings count amounts to claiming that one creates all value in the world.

He supplants God as the creator of order and value in the external world, which exists only to the extent that he allows it to exist. There will be no light unless he says, “Let there be light.” God has been dispensed with. This retreat into pure emotion, this solipsistic negation of the world, is a kind of black Mass, an alternative to Christian blessedness.

In this respect, the stance portrayed by Goethe can be compared with the stance toward existence adopted by D. H. Lawrence in the twentieth century. Emotion is central. Lawrence’s conception of sex also includes physicality, at least to some extent, but the key idea is that the self creates all value.

In a work such as *The Plumed Serpent*, new religions are constructed to replace the ancient Christian religion. In this interpretation, they amount to the same thing: nihilistic ego-worship, the worship of oneself alone. Werther thinks he worships Charlotte, but actually worships his conception of her.

His conception relates to the real Charlotte as the model for the Statue of Liberty relates to the statue itself. There is an enormous disproportion. Werther, the creator of all value, mythically inflates something accidental and arbitrary into something universally—or at least personally—significant. He adopts an attitude toward existence that Lawrence later articulates and develops.

The difference between Werther’s stance, perhaps shared up to a point by the young Goethe, and Lawrence’s is that Goethe is willing to confront its nihilistic implications. The novel ends in death because abolishing the external world amounts to abolishing the self.

The religious overtones suggest, both here and perhaps in Lawrence’s novels, that emotion becomes a new god replacing the God of love and hope who had been a traditional foundation of Western culture. Completely breaking our connection to society also breaks our connection to its characteristic structures of value, and those structures are life-giving.

I think Lawrence is unwilling to confront this because he is too committed to the idea. In some respects, he is a new Werther who does not kill himself. Goethe, by contrast, is sufficiently protean to use the novel as a catharsis. He knew a young man who had killed himself and had himself experienced an unhappy love affair. He fused these

experiences into an artistic creation that made him a major figure in Western European literature and allowed him to move on to other concerns.

That is why Goethe is a more important and profound artistic figure than Lawrence. Lawrence has a one-track mind: emotion, sex, and this world, endlessly varied versions of the same theme. Goethe is sufficiently protean and creative to begin at that level and move toward affirming other things.

One cannot imagine someone wholly committed to self-worship and to the nihilistic insistence that emotion and desire are the only sources of value eventually producing *Faust*. *Faust* spiritualizes lust, turning it into desire not only for sex and sexual satisfaction, but also for knowledge, beauty, truth, and abstract things that remain legitimate objects of desire. Desire has been spiritualized rather than physicalized.

Werther therefore represents a dead end that Goethe himself can move beyond. In doing so, Goethe achieves catharsis for his own tremendous emotional turmoil. To produce such an important early work at twenty-four, in four weeks, demonstrates his place among the great geniuses of the Western intellectual tradition.

He is often compared with Shakespeare. Frankly, I do not think Shakespeare can stand alongside him in every respect. I have the greatest admiration for Shakespeare, but he was not a statesman, did little in science, and remained largely within literature. Goethe could compete with Shakespeare as a literary figure and do a great deal more.

The Sorrows of Young Werther offers exceptionally immediate rewards. I know no one who has not found it a tremendous experience. It does not demand the months one might devote to *Faust*. The two hours or so of time and thought required for this short novel are richly rewarded. Its beauty is that one can experience it again and again without its losing its flavour, freshness, or beauty.